

Hungary's €10B corruption test

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By MAX GRIERA JÓ REGGELT!

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JÓ REGGELT! I'm Max Griera, for our last day together on our tour of EU capitals. Today we're in Budapest, which is nursing a hangover after celebrating its national holiday, St. Stephen's Day, with fireworks, drone shows and music blasting through the streets.

Taking a stroll in the Castle Hill area of the Hungarian capital, I walked past the prime minister's office where, four months ago, I sat for a heated interview with Viktor Orbán's spokesperson. The building now houses the Ministry of Social Affairs and Family and a new plaque greets visitors: "The Orbán government's hate propaganda was directed from this building. Now it serves social cohesion and human dignity."

In today's Playbook:

- Meet the man tasked with "de-Orbánizing" Hungary.
- Didn't take the CAST test? We've got you covered.
- Faces in the crowd: Zoltán Tarr, Jean-Eric Paquet, Ferenc Pál Biró, Pedro Sánchez, Balázs Orbán, Marine Le Pen, Jean-Luc Mélenchon, Jim Ratcliffe, and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender: Sarah and guests discuss the European Commission's attempts to forge a common stance on China.

DRIVING THE DAY

CASH WITH CAUTION: As Hungary gets closer to an end of August deadline for unlocking over €10 billion in frozen EU cash, its top anti-graft watchdog is warning that pouring so much money into a system with a long history of corruption could create fresh opportunities for abuse.

After years of corruption being tolerated, Hungary's institutions still need to stay alert for fraud even as Péter Magyar's new government promises a clean break, Integrity Authority chief Ferenc Pál Biró told Playbook. "When you are pushed to spend a lot of money, there will be a number of individuals ... aiming to misuse these opportunities," Biró said.

Choreography: Hungary's government has until Aug. 31 to fast-track reforms that sufficiently satisfy the European Commission for it to release €10.4 billion that Hungary is entitled to under the EU's post-pandemic recovery fund. The money was withheld over Budapest's breaches of EU law under Viktor Orbán. But Budapest does now appear on track to get the money, two EU officials, granted anonymity to speak freely about a sensitive topic, told Playbook.

"We are working extremely hard on this," Culture Minister Zoltán Tarr told me at a national day event on Budapest's Margaret Island. "Many ministries, many colleagues are not doing anything else, just working on this." Tarr — water-bottle in hand, wearing a straw hat to fend off the sun — said he expects a small amount of money to be withheld over missed milestones, but is confident the bulk of the cash will flow. He said the government has heard that the Commission is "satisfied with the steps which we have made so far."

The Integrity Authority, founded in 2022 as part of reforms pushed by Brussels, monitors the spending and security of EU funds. After years of what Biró claims was pressure and intimidation under Orbán — including demands to drop investigations — his office has gained new powers and fresh momentum under Magyar.

Shackles off: Biró said many cases he flagged for investigation under Orbán are now "resurfacing," as officials who "always wanted to do the right thing" are now free to do so. One case involves a €650,000 contract allegedly awarded without a tender to the brother of a senior Fidesz politician at a cost the Integrity Authority said was 51 times the going rate. Another case involves the €275 million EU-funded Gondosóra program for the elderly, now under investigation by Hungary's tax authority for suspected fraud.

Plenty of work to do: Biró estimates that under Orbán, some €105 billion in public funds ended up in private hands or left the country. He believes a "fairly large proportion" can be recovered, though much may be in places such as the Caribbean and Latin America, making recovery a yearslong process. His watchdog has scrutinized around €1 billion in EU funds in the past two years.

Give us time: Biró stopped short of giving Magyar's anti-corruption drive a clean bill of health. "Has the government done enough at this point? It's difficult to say," Biró said, adding that he'll withhold judgment on that until 2027 while the government is still undertaking reforms.

Fidesz hits back: Orbán's former political director, Balázs Orbán, now an MEP, pushed back on the corruption allegations and accused the new government of political bias. "It is absolutely outrageous that, under these circumstances, the new liberal Hungarian government enjoys unprecedented support from the Brussels institutions, while those same institutions remain completely silent in the face of anti-democratic measures of exactly the kind they previously accused Viktor Orbán's governments of taking," he said.

"The new government has moved to grant the [Integrity] Authority extraordinarily extensive powers, going beyond those enjoyed by comparable bodies elsewhere in the European Union," Balázs Orbán added. "In just 100 days, we have witnessed measures unprecedented in Hungary's post-communist democratic history."

BIG AND BREAKING

EUROPE'S GREEN DILEMMA: INEOS, the industrial giant controlled by Manchester United co-owner Jim Ratcliffe, had a plan to revive Europe's chemicals sector — but its half-finished €5 billion Antwerp petrochemical factory is instead mired in a legal stalemate , Jakob Weizman reports.

WASHINGTON'S DEBT, EVERYONE'S PROBLEM: Europe's governments are getting squeezed as jitters about the Middle East war and the U.S.'s \$40 trillion debt — not to mention the AI arms race — push up borrowing costs , Geoffrey Smith writes.

NATO'S FRENCH NIGHTMARE: Around half of French voters back presidential candidates who are hostile to the alliance: Marine Le Pen, who wants France out of NATO's integrated command, and Jean-Luc Mélenchon, who wants out altogether.

CULTURE WARS

DE-ORBÁNIZATION: I met Tarr, Hungary's culture minister, at the governing Tisza party's national day gathering. A former pastor in the Reformed church, Tarr has been at Magyar's side from the start, later leading Tisza's MEPs in Brussels. Now, he has one of the government's most sensitive tasks:

"De-Orbánizing" Hungarian society, with a portfolio spanning culture, religion, media and civil society.

I asked Tarr about the plaque at the former PM's office that I mentioned at the top, and whether the government plans to make this type of naming and shaming a long-term policy. "It is very important to make sure that we don't forget what has happened," Tarr said, even as the country tries to move on from the Orbán years.

"Every day we find big surprises," Tarr added, claiming that examples of corruption have been found in every ministry. "It is really, really surprising and astonishing the extent of how bad things were and are still."

Keeping the record: Magyar's parliamentary sessions have so far been a running exercise in criticizing the opposition Fidesz party. Orbán's lavishly renovated former residence has been opened to public tours. And now some groups want to create a museum dedicated to the Orbán era and its alleged corruption. Tarr said he'd ensure communities can build such spaces.

Tarr said he's already revisiting museum exhibitions, including at Budapest's House of Terror and the Hungarian parliament, to determine whether they "really fit the historic understanding, the facts ... or [whether] they just reflect a very narrow, politically influenced understanding" of Hungarian history.

And in schools: "A major, major part" of Tisza's plan is to "get into the depths of the educational curricula and to, again, depoliticize," Tarr said, citing history and literature classes as priorities. Magyar's government also plans to end the centralized textbook system and open the market to competing books and teaching approaches.

NGOs, religious groups, and cultural organizations grew accustomed to "very clear political expectations" under Orbán, Tarr said. The new administration exerting less political influence has left some organizations "disoriented." But "we have to move the country forward," he said.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

UPHILL BATTLE: Spanish leader Pedro Sánchez has so many problems piling up that he might decide to go to the polls early, my colleague Aitor Hernández-Morales reports.

MILKING IMAGINARY COWS: Greek farmers claimed EU subsidies for tens of thousands more farm animals in 2024 than the country's official records can account for, according to government data analyzed by Nektaria Stamouli. The finding threatens to add to a wider Greek farm-subsidy scandal .

INSIDE MANC-A-LAGO: No. 10 North, Andy Burnham's regional government hub in Manchester, is central to the new British PM's push to move power out of London, Dan Bloom reports in a deep dive for POLITICO Magazine .

DRONE WARS: Merchant ships are increasingly coming under attack in Russia's war against Ukraine, setting off a maritime arms race .

A BUMPY RIDE: Paul Dallison's latest Declassified column looks at the links between politics and theme parks .

BUDAPEST CORNER

WHERE TO EAT: Head to Gerlőczy Kávéház for the grand-café experience in Budapest without the tourist hordes. Tucked into a quiet square between city hall and the Great Synagogue, it's also the perfect place to work: the usually empty interior has plenty of tables and power outlets.

COMMUNIST STATUES: The Memento Park is well worth the €8 entry fee and hour-long trek on public transport. Spread across a leafy site on Budapest's outskirts are 41 monumental statues retired after the fall of Hungary's communist dictatorship in 1989. Tickets and info .

HOSPITAL IN THE ROCK ... is a museum inside a former underground wartime hospital and nuclear bunker carved into the cave system beneath Buda Castle. Visitors can walk its narrow corridors and cramped operating rooms reliving the siege of Budapest at the end of World War II, the failed 1956 revolution against communist dictatorship and the era of Soviet domination. Check it out.

OTTOMAN BATHS: The grand but touristy Széchenyi Baths are a must for first-timers, but the real hidden gem is Rudas , home to a Turkish bath dating back to the 16th century during the Ottoman occupation of Buda. Tip: Check ahead to see whether it's a men's, women's or mixed-gender day.

Playbook came to Brussels in 2015 and changed how this town starts its day. It has now landed in Canberra: a capital with just as many officials and, until now, no daily briefing of its own. Canberra Playbook: free, daily, radically impartial. Subscribe free .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals, changing to showers in the afternoon. High 21C.

TASTE OF INDIA: Brussels' Indian Food Festival will take place in Parc du Cinquantenaire this weekend. The 10th edition of the festival will involve cultural workshops and Bollywood-style flash mobs, along with delicious cuisine from across the subcontinent — all recreating an Indian mela (fair).

LIFE BEYOND CAST: Yesterday, Playbook told you why your LinkedIn feed is suddenly overflowing with people celebrating their CAST results. But don't despair if you didn't take the test — there are plenty of

EU jobs you can apply for the old-fashioned way, Playbook's Gerardo Fortuna writes in.

We went vacancy-hunting and picked the three best (and coolest) EU jobs currently up for grabs that don't require a test:

1. Yes, chef: The EU delegation to Japan is looking for a chef for the ambassador's residence in Minato. The brief: get creative "combining European, Japanese and Asian cuisine." Basic Japanese is a plus. But hurry up — applications close on Tuesday. (If Ambassador Jean-Eric Paquet is reading, feel free to tell Playbook — and prospective candidates — your favorite dish).

2. Bookworm wanted: Yes, the European Commission still has librarians — and it's hiring one. The successful candidate will work shifts in the reading room and help library users, but the main gig is sourcing and acquiring the knowledge Brussels' bureaucratic machine needs to keep turning: dealing with publishers and contractors, managing acquisitions and creating bibliographic records. Applications close on Sept. 4.

3. Tough assignment: And if neither Tokyo nor the library appeals, how about Fiji? The EU delegation there is looking for someone to lead its strategic communications team, covering Fiji and another 12 Pacific island countries — including the Cook Islands, Palau, Samoa and Vanuatu. Someone has to represent the European Union in paradise (for the sake of Europe, obviously). Applications close on Sept. 1.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Saxony-Anhalt premier Sven Schulze is distancing himself from a CDU colleague's €10,000 donation to the AfD, as his party trails the far right in the polls.

Paris: François Bayrou has angered his own camp by proposing former European Commissioner Thierry Breton as a presidential candidate.

London: Andy Burnham is gathering allies in No. 10 North today to discuss how to push his devolution agenda.

Washington: Massachusetts Democratic Senate Seth Moulton is pitching himself as one of a new generation of fighters who can pressure the Trump administration to end the Iran war.

Canberra: A new AI blindspot is opening up.

AGENDA

— Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto attends the opening ceremony of the XX Mediterranean Games in Taranto, Italy.

— Democracy Commissioner Michael McGrath will speak at Ukraine's National Flag Day ceremony on Sunday.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Loucas Furlas, Esteban González Pons and Giuseppe Milazzo; former MEP Ondřej Kovařík; Cédric de Meeûs from Holcim; FT's Laura Dubois; Tobias Teuscher, former deputy secretary-general of the European Parliament's Identity & Democracy group; Blanka Glasenhardt from Croatia's permanent delegation to NATO.

Celebrating Saturday: MEP Pascal Canfin; former MEPs Demetris Papadakis and Igor Šoltes; Brunswick's Patrick Matthews; European Jewish Public Affairs' Levi Matusof; Manuela Teixeira Pinto, Portugal's former deputy permanent representative to the EU; former European Commissioner Julian King.

Celebrating Sunday: Democracy Commissioner Michael McGrath; former MEPs Maria Manuel Leitão Marques, Brian Hayes and Andrzej Grzyb; European Commission's Eoin O'Malley; Miriam Sapiro, former deputy and USTR; European Parliament's Hugo Salek; AP's Nebi Qena; Queen Noor of Jordan; Halimah Yacob, former president of Singapore.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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